



Founder Pedigree

Traction

in EUR		Some Pedigree	Senior Pedigree	Experienced Founder	Successful Founder
	Everyone else	WHU, CDTM, TUM, Ivy League McK, BCG, Goldman; Key track at scaleup	Key Role or Key early employee at scaleup (strong references)	Eg.: Raised from VCs or built startup to decent size. No meaningful exit.	Eg.: Built company to >100m valuation, successful exit
Idea on Paper	0-100k	0-300k	1m	2m	>5m
First product live No validation	0-300k	300-800k	1m	2m	>5m
Product live Medium indications of demand	300-800k	500k-1.5m	1-3m	2-5m	>5m
Product live Strong indications of demand	1-3m	2.5-5m	2.5-5m	2-5m	>5m

	Levelling-up-cheats <i>Move one field to the right</i>	Handicaps <i>Move one field to the left</i>
Trends	Follow the hype: If you are building within the currently hottest topic in investor-land you will have an easier time fundraising. <i>Example:</i> If in 2023 you are raising for a generative AI company in climate-tech, then move one field to the right. <i>Danger:</i> This advantage can quickly turn into a handicap as lots of startups flood into these fields and investors sour on these topics.	Going against the trend: If you are pitching within a an anti-hype segment, you will have an uphill struggle. <i>Example:</i> A web3 NFT launcher in 2023.
Signalling	Use signalling powers: Some individuals have a lot of credibility and can through endorsement seriously enhance a founder's pedigree. <i>Examples:</i> A unicorn founder agrees to be your first angel investor. Bill Gates or Angela Merkel agree to be your advisors. Your former boss, who is a successful entrepreneur, and has worked closely with you, invests into your company.	Burned reputation: The VC ecosystem is a small world and everyone knows everyone. Investors do backchannel references through founder's former employers, co-founders or investors before investing. A negative reputation whether deserved or undeserved extremely quickly kills a fundraise.